# Salvation History Timeline

Leader Guide — For Servants, Parents, and Group Leaders

> *"And beginning at Moses and all the Prophets, He expounded to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning Himself." — Luke 24:27*

## Purpose of This Guide

This guide helps you lead Salvation History Timeline as a formation experience, not just a game. Each era summary gives you the narrative arc, the Coptic connections, and discussion questions to draw out deeper understanding. The goal is to help players see one continuous story — God's plan of salvation unfolding through time, with every event pointing toward Christ.

## Before You Begin

- **Pray together.** Begin with a short prayer: "Lord, open our eyes to see Your hand in history and Your love in every age. Amen."
- **Set the context.** Tell the group: "The Bible isn't a collection of separate stories. It's one story — God's plan to save and be with His people. Today we're going to build that story together."
- **Choose your mode.** Competitive mode works well for kids who know some Bible stories. Cooperative mode is ideal for younger or less experienced groups.

## Era 1: Creation and Patriarchs

### The Story

God creates the world in love and makes humanity in His image. But sin enters through disobedience, and death follows. Yet God does not abandon His creation. He promises a Savior (Genesis 3:15 — the "Protoevangelium"), preserves humanity through Noah, and calls Abraham to begin a new family through whom all nations will be blessed.

The patriarchs — Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Joseph — are not perfect. They stumble, deceive, and doubt. But God's faithfulness does not depend on human faithfulness. He keeps His covenant promises through every generation.

### Coptic Connections

- The Coptic Church reads Genesis during Holy Week, connecting creation to re-creation through the Cross.
- The binding of Isaac (Genesis 22) is read on Good Friday — Abraham's willingness to sacrifice his only son prefigures the Father's offering of Christ.
- Jacob's ladder (Genesis 28) is an icon of the Theotokos — she is the ladder by which God descended to earth.

### Discussion Questions

- Why did God keep His promise even when people sinned?
- How is Abraham's faith different from what the world calls "faith"?
- What does it mean that God "called" Abraham? Does God still call people today?

## Era 2: Exodus and Conquest

### The Story

Israel is enslaved in Egypt. God hears their cry and sends Moses to deliver them. Through ten plagues, the Passover, and the parting of the Red Sea, God demonstrates that He alone is God and that He fights for His people. At Sinai, He gives them the Law — not as a burden, but as a covenant relationship: "I will be your God, and you will be My people."

Yet the people grumble, worship the golden calf, and wander forty years in the wilderness. God provides manna, water from the rock, and the tabernacle — His visible presence among them. Joshua leads them into the Promised Land, and Jericho falls not by military might but by obedient faith.

### Coptic Connections

- The Passover lamb prefigures Christ, the Lamb of God. The Coptic Liturgy of St. Basil echoes this: "The Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world."
- Crossing the Red Sea is a type of baptism (1 Corinthians 10:1-2). The Coptic baptismal rite recalls this deliverance.

- Manna prefigures the Eucharist — Jesus says “I am the bread of life” (John 6:35). The Coptic prosphora (communion bread) carries this typology.
- The burning bush is an icon of the Theotokos — she bore the fire of divinity without being consumed.

### Discussion Questions

- God heard Israel's cry in Egypt. What does that tell us about how God responds to suffering?
- Why did God make the people wander for 40 years? What were they supposed to learn?
- How is the Eucharist like manna? How is it different?

## Era 3: Judges and Kings

### The Story

In the Promised Land, Israel enters a cycle of faithfulness, sin, oppression, and deliverance. God raises up judges — Deborah, Gideon, Samson — to rescue His people when they repent. But the people demand a king like the other nations. God gives them Saul, then David, then Solomon.

David is a man after God's own heart — a shepherd, warrior, poet, and sinner who repents. God makes an everlasting covenant with David: his descendant will sit on the throne forever. Solomon builds the Temple, but his wisdom turns to folly, and the kingdom divides.

### Coptic Connections

- The Psalms of David are the backbone of Coptic worship. The Agpeya (Book of Hours) is structured around the Psalms, prayed seven times daily.
- Every Gospel reading in the Coptic Liturgy is preceded by a Psalm — David's voice introduces Christ's words.
- The Coptic Church sees David's repentance (Psalm 51) as the model for the Sacrament of Confession.
- Solomon's Temple prefigures the Church — the place where God's glory dwells among His people.

### Discussion Questions

- What does it mean that David was “a man after God's own heart” even though he sinned?
- Why does God allow His people to have an earthly king, even though He knows it will lead to problems?
- How do the Psalms help us pray? Do you have a favorite Psalm?

## Era 4: Prophets and Exile

### The Story

God sends prophets to call His people back: Elijah, Isaiah, Jeremiah, Daniel, and many others. They warn of judgment, call for repentance, and promise a coming Messiah. But the people do not listen. The northern kingdom falls to Assyria (722 BC). Judah falls to Babylon (586 BC). The Temple is destroyed, and God's people are taken into exile.

Yet even in exile, God does not abandon them. Daniel and the three holy youth demonstrate faithfulness under persecution. Esther saves her people. And after seventy years, God brings them home. The Temple is rebuilt, and the people wait — for centuries — for the promised Messiah.

### Coptic Connections

- Isaiah's prophecies of the Suffering Servant (Isaiah 53) are read extensively during Holy Week in the Coptic Church.
- The three holy youth in the furnace (Daniel 3) are celebrated in the Coptic hymn “Tenen” sung during the midnight praise (Tasbeha).
- The Holy Family's flight to Egypt (Matthew 2:13-15) fulfills Hosea 11:1 and is one of the most beloved Coptic feasts. Egypt — once the land of slavery — becomes the land that shelters the Savior.
- The Coptic Church traces its identity to this moment: Christ Himself blessed the land of Egypt.

### Discussion Questions

- Why did God send prophets instead of just punishing the people immediately?
- What does the exile teach us about the consequences of turning away from God?
- Why is the Holy Family's journey to Egypt so important to the Coptic Church?
- Daniel and the three youth were faithful in a pagan culture. How can we be faithful in our culture?

## Era 5: The Incarnation

### The Story

After centuries of waiting, God acts. The Archangel Gabriel appears to a young virgin in Nazareth: “You will conceive and bear a Son.” Mary's “yes” opens the door for God to enter His own creation. The Word becomes flesh.

Jesus is born in Bethlehem, baptized in the Jordan, tempted in the wilderness, and begins His public ministry. He teaches the Kingdom of God, heals the sick, raises the dead, and calls twelve apostles. He reveals that the entire Old Testament was about Him.

He enters Jerusalem on Palm Sunday, shares the Last Supper — instituting the Eucharist — and is crucified on Good Friday. On the third day, He rises from the dead, conquering sin and death forever. After forty days, He ascends to heaven, promising to send the Holy Spirit.

### Coptic Connections

- The Coptic Church professes the faith of St. Cyril of Alexandria: Christ is one nature — the incarnate nature of God the Word (miaphysite Christology). He is fully God and fully man, united without confusion, mixture, or separation.
- The Theotokos (God-bearer) holds a central place in Coptic devotion. Every Coptic liturgy includes hymns to the Virgin Mary.
- The Coptic Holy Week (Pascha) is the most solemn week of the year. Every event from Palm Sunday through the Resurrection is relived in extended prayers, readings, and hymns.
- The Resurrection is proclaimed in the Coptic greeting: “Ekhrestos anesti! Alethos anesti!” (Christ is risen! Truly He is risen!)

### Discussion Questions

- Why did God choose to become human rather than save us from a distance?
- How did Jesus' miracles show that the Kingdom of God was arriving?
- What does it mean that Jesus instituted the Eucharist at the Passover meal?
- Why is the Resurrection the most important event in all of history?

## Era 6: The Early Church

### The Story

At Pentecost, the Holy Spirit descends on the apostles. The Church is born. Peter preaches boldly, and three thousand are baptized in one day. The apostles heal, teach, and face persecution with joy.

Stephen becomes the first martyr, forgiving his killers as Christ did. Saul the persecutor encounters the risen Christ and becomes Paul, the apostle to the Gentiles. The Council of Jerusalem decides that the Gospel is for all nations, not just the Jews.

St. Mark brings the faith to Alexandria, founding what will become the Coptic Orthodox Church. The Gospel spreads from Jerusalem to Rome, from Antioch to Egypt, carried by apostles who give their lives for the truth they have seen.

### Coptic Connections

- The Coptic Church traces its founding to St. Mark the Evangelist (c. AD 49). He is considered the first Pope of Alexandria.
- The Coptic Liturgy of St. Mark is one of the oldest liturgies in Christendom, reflecting the worship of the apostolic church in Egypt.
- The tradition of martyrdom is central to Coptic identity. The Coptic calendar begins in AD 284, the “Era of the Martyrs,” honoring those who died for the faith under Diocletian.
- Pentecost is celebrated fifty days after the Resurrection. The Coptic Church emphasizes that the Holy Spirit continues to dwell in the Church and in every believer through Chrismation (the sacrament of Confirmation).

### Discussion Questions

- How did the Holy Spirit change the apostles at Pentecost?
- Why is it significant that St. Mark brought the Gospel to Egypt?
- What does it mean that the Coptic calendar is called the “Era of the Martyrs”?
- How does the Church continue the work of the apostles today?

## Typology: How the Old Points to the New

One of the richest aspects of this game is helping players see how Old Testament events prefigure (foreshadow) New Testament realities. The Church Fathers called these connections “types” and “antitypes.” Here are some key typological connections in the game:

| Old Testament Type | New Testament Fulfillment |
|---|---|
| Abel's sacrifice | Christ, the perfect offering |
| Noah's Ark | The Church — salvation through water (1 Peter 3:20–21) |
| The binding of Isaac | The Crucifixion — the Father offers His only Son |
| Jacob's ladder | The Theotokos — the ladder between heaven and earth |
| Joseph sold by his brothers | Christ betrayed, yet saving those who betrayed Him |
| The Passover lamb | Christ, the Lamb of God (John 1:29) |
| Crossing the Red Sea | Baptism (1 Corinthians 10:1–2) |
| Manna from heaven | The Eucharist — the true Bread of Life (John 6) |
| The bronze serpent | Christ lifted up on the Cross (John 3:14) |
| The burning bush | The Theotokos — bearing divinity without being consumed |
| Jonah — three days in the fish | Christ — three days in the tomb (Matthew 12:40) |
| Solomon's Temple | The Church — where God's glory dwells |

> **Activity idea:** After the game, challenge players to find more types and antitypes in the completed timeline. “Can you find an Old Testament event that points to something in the New Testament?” This builds the habit of reading Scripture the way the Church Fathers read it — always looking for Christ.

## Connecting to the Coptic Lectionary

The Coptic lectionary assigns Old Testament, Psalm, Epistle, and Gospel readings for every liturgy. This means the Church already connects the eras of salvation history every week! Here are some opportunities to pair the game with the lectionary:

- **Great Lent:** Focus on repentance events — the Fall, the Golden Calf, David's repentance, Jonah, the Prodigal Son.
- **Holy Week:** Walk through Era 5 in detail, connecting each event to the corresponding Holy Week readings.
- **Pentecost season:** Focus on Era 6 and the spread of the Gospel.
- **Feast of the Cross:** Highlight typological connections — the bronze serpent, Abraham's sacrifice, the Crucifixion.
- **Feast of the Holy Family in Egypt:** Use the “Holy Family in Egypt” card to discuss God's special blessing on the land of Egypt.
- **Nayrouz (Coptic New Year):** Discuss the era of martyrdom and the Early Church's witness.

## Closing Prayer

> *Lord Jesus Christ, You are the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end. You are present in every page of Scripture and every era of history. Open our eyes to see Your hand at work — in the past, in our lives today, and in the age to come. Through the prayers of the Theotokos, the apostles, and all the saints, keep us faithful in Your one, holy, apostolic Church. Amen.*

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